

Change Leadership

The work of establishing direction and mobilising people through a transition

GLOSSARY 02 - SHEET 5 / 8

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Change leadership is the work of establishing direction, aligning people to it and motivating them through a transition, as distinct from change management, which is the work of planning, resourcing, sequencing and controlling that transition. Leadership addresses the human transition that follows an organisational change; management addresses the change itself, and the two are complementary rather than interchangeable (Kotter, 1996; Bridges, 1991).

WHO DEFINED IT ORIGINALLY

John P. Kotter drew the leadership-management distinction at Harvard Business School and set out the eight-stage process in *Leading Change* (1996), following his 1995 Harvard Business Review analysis of why transformation efforts fail. William Bridges (1991) supplied the parallel psychological account of transition; Kurt Lewin's (1947) three-step model is the common antecedent.

WHY THIS DEFINITION WAS DEVELOPED

Kotter observed that most large-scale change efforts produced disappointing results despite competent project management, and concluded that firms were over-managing and under-leading. The distinction was needed because the two activities fail differently: management failure shows as a missed milestone, leadership failure shows as a delivered system that nobody uses.

FIGURE 1 - LEADERSHIP AND MANAGEMENT ARE DIFFERENT WORK



Figure 1. The two columns fail differently. Management failure appears as a missed milestone and is detected early; leadership failure appears as a completed deployment that nobody uses, and is detected only after the budget has been spent (after Kotter, 1996).

HOW IT IS USED

Use the eight stages as a diagnostic of what has been skipped rather than as a linear checklist; in practice most stalled programmes have skipped the first stage, urgency, and cannot be repaired at the stage where the symptom appeared.

WHEN IT IS USED

At the launch of an AI adoption programme, when a technically complete deployment has low usage, when resistance appears late, and when a coalition of sponsors has quietly dissolved.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Executive sponsors of transformation, transformation directors, business unit leaders carrying the change into operations, and human resources partners supporting the transition.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Lewin's unfreeze-change-refreeze model treated organisations as systems returning to equilibrium, and gave no account of what leaders do inside each phase. Kotter's eight stages decompose the sequence into observable managerial acts and, critically, identify skipping as the dominant failure mode. Bridges added the insight that the transition runs on a different clock from the change: the organisation can be restructured on Monday while its people are still in the neutral zone months later.

RELATED DEFINITIONS IN THIS COURSE

Change Management - Unit 4

Organisational Culture - Unit 2

Psychological Safety - Unit 2

AI Adoption - Unit 4

Upper Echelons Theory - Unit 2

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

- Bridges, W. (1991) *Managing Transitions: Making the Most of Change*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.
- Kotter, J.P. (1995) 'Leading change: why transformation efforts fail', *Harvard Business Review*, 73(2), pp. 59-67.
- Kotter, J.P. (1996) *Leading Change*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Press.
- Lewin, K. (1947) 'Frontiers in group dynamics', *Human Relations*, 1(1), pp. 5-41.